Howlite

△ **Several nodules** of howlite on a rock matrix

Popular with collectors, howlite is generally found in nodules, in which it is usually white with veins of other minerals running through it. It is relatively porous and absorbs dye well, in particular blue dye: when altered in this way, it resembles, and is sometimes erroneously sold as, turquoise. Fortunately it is easily distinguished from turquoise since it is much softer, although it can still be polished. Howlite is found in quantity in Death Valley, California, USA. It was named after the Canadian chemist, Henry How, who discovered it in 1868.

Specification

Chemical name Calcium borosilicate | **Formula** $Ca_2B_5SiO_9(OH)_5$ | **Colours** White | **Structure** Monoclinic **Hardness** 3.5 | **SG** 2.6 | **RI** 1.58–1.61 | **Lustre** Subvitreous **Streak** White | **Locations** USA, Canada, Mexico, Germany, Russia, Turkey

Howlite nodule | **Rough** | Howlite is sometimes found in cauliflower-like nodules like this one, which can be dyed to resemble turquoise nuggets (see far right).

Polished pebble | **Cut** | A tumble-polished example of natural, uncoloured howlite showing the veining common in many specimens.

Dyed and tumbled | **Cut** | A popular form of howlite for collectors, many specimens are tumbled and dyed various shades of blue-green to resemble turquoise.

Dyed howlite | **Cut** | This tumble-polished specimen of howlite has also been dyed to look like turquoise, with a different shade and a more highly polished surface.

Howlite pendant | **Carved** | This finely sculpted, veined howlite horse-head carving featuring onyx eyes is set in a frame fashioned from 18-karat gold.

Carved frog | **Carved** | Howlite is soft but tough, which means it makes an excellent material for carving. This fanciful, veined howlite frog carving has a smooth surface and is set with onyx cabochons for eyes.